The Karen position was problematic. The Karen population is not monolith; numerous factions both religiously and politically were apparent. A Karen state would have been vulnerable to external powers. Finally, a Karen state would have been difficult to sustain economically.

The advantages of the Karen insurgency were numerous. The Karen National Liberation Army was well trained by the British and also had sufficient weapons. The anarchy ensuing in Burma made the timing for an insurrection practical. With numerous insurgencies emerging from both ethnic and political organizations, the Karen leadership felt a sense of confidence during the 1947–1949 period.

The clear starting date for the actual insurrection is disputed. Some historians cite the rebellion starting in the summer of 1948. The Palaw massacre in Tenasserim in December 1948, in which 80 Karen peasants were slaughtered, clearly increased the tension level. Other sources mark the 1949 battle of Insein as the beginning point.

By early 1949, the tide seemed to be turning in the Karen direction. An alliance with communist rebels led to the capture of Mandalay. During the summer, much of the countryside was under rebel control. The Karen forces, bolstered by desertions from the Burmese military, may have outnumbered government forces three to one. Lieutenant General Ne Win replaced the Burmese military chief, a Karen named Smith-Dun. Making matters worst, the Karen success led to increased rebel activities from ethnic groups, as well as communist supporters boosted by Mao Zedong's success in the Chinese civil war in 1949.

The Karen movement suffered from factionalization, which seriously damaged the insurgency at a critical time. Karen sympathy for communism, while being a predominately Christian group, was troubling at times. The Cold War proxy situation in Southeast Asia probably hurt the unity of Karen nationalism as members of the movement became engulfed in the drug operations in the Golden Triangle region. Finally, alliances between the different insurgency groups were always temporary as the Burmese state was able to divide and conquer at appropriate times.

ADDITIONAL ETHNIC ISSUES